

PTI

**ANSWERING BACK**
Congress workers in Bengaluru protest BJP MP Tejasvi Surya's claims regarding the Waqf notices to landowners, November 9

'land jihad'. "There's a ploy to transfer thousands of acres to Waqf before the central amendment comes in. We wanted to expose this," claimed Surya on November 7, pointing to the Waqf adalats that had been organised by Karnataka's minister for Waqfs, B.Z. Zameer Ahmed Khan, in various districts over the past few months.

While Khan maintains that the adalats were held to resolve grievances such as encroachment on Waqf properties, it turned out that some notices in Vijayapura had been erroneously issued by district authorities. Since October 7, when a Waqf adalat was held in Vijayapura, 124 notices had been issued in the district. Dismissing the BJP's claim that as many as 1,200 acres was being claimed in Honavada village alone, Vijayapura district-in charge minister M.B. Patil clarifies that no farmer from this village received any notice and that the Waqf assets here, namely a kabristan and dargah, span only 12 acres. Patil, however, admits to some confusion in the exercise. For instance, an incorrect survey number caused a notice to be issued to the Virakta matha—a 13th century Veerashaiva-Lingayat institution, while record mutations to enter claims had been done for 41 properties in Hindi, without issuing due notice. Patil, who says "not an inch of farmers' land would go to Waqf", set up a district task force to verify properties registered as Waqf over the past 50 years.

Karnataka first surveyed Waqf properties and notified these in 1974, but the process of registering Waqf ownership in records didn't take place. During this era, there were sweeping changes in land redistribution under Inam abolition laws—pertaining to land and charitable grants as Waqf—and the Karnataka Land Reforms Act 1974, where land was granted to the tiller. According to Zameer Ahmed Khan, out of around 112,000 acres of Waqf land in Karnataka, about 75,000 acres was handed away through the two laws and another significant portion was lost to encroachment, so that the Waqf manages only 23,860 acres currently. A total of 47,470 Waqf properties are being overseen by the Karnataka State Board of Auqafs, which also pursues litigation to reclaim encroached land.

On November 2, Chief Minister Siddaramaiah ordered all Waqf notices to be withdrawn—423 notices had been issued in five districts since the Congress assumed office in June 2023—and subsequently put a halt to all land record mutations related to Waqf claims. The ruling party also sought to prove that the BJP was at fault—on November 8, M.B. Patil released records to show that similar mutations in land registry had been carried out routinely during the BJP's previous two terms in Karnataka. Moreover, the BJP government had set up district-level task forces in 2021 to protect Waqf assets. Patil accuses the BJP of raking up the issue with the bypolls in mind and, equally, in preparation for the upcoming Parliament session where the Waqf Amendment Bill is sure to generate heat. The last word has yet to be spoken. ■

## HALT ORDER

- **In the past year, the Karnataka revenue authorities issued over 400 notices to properties, based on Waqf claims**
- **Protesting BJP accuses the ruling Congress of 'appeasement' politics**
- **On Nov. 2, CM Siddaramaiah ordered all Waqf notices to be withdrawn, put a halt to all land record mutations related to Waqf claims**
- **He says the previous BJP regime in Karnataka had also issued 216 such notices**